

Early american ciphers

America had no centralized organization dedicated to cryptography. Here, decryption was undertaken by interested individuals. The first instance of encryption dates back to 1775, when a letter from Dr. Benjamin Church was intercepted. The coded message was suspected to be vital information for the British. However, the revolutionaries were unable to decipher it. Later on, Elbridge Gerry (who went on to become the fifth Vice President) and Elisha Porter solved the cipher. The message proved Benjamin Church guilty of transferring information to the Tories and he was exiled. The cipher was a simple one where each correspondent had a code book. Each word of the message was replaced by a number representing its place in the book. For example, 3.7.9 meant page 3, line 7 and word 9 in the code book.

Ciphers were also employed by the revolutionaries during the American Revolution. General George Washington was informed about the British troops and their movements around New York City through Samuel Woodhull and Robert Townsend. Their code was a cache of numbers which was substituted for words. This was written by Major Benjamin Tallmadge and also used invisible ink for increased security.

Rapid advancements

James Lovell is considered as the father of American Cryptology. He was true to America and helped the revolutionaries decipher the British codes. This helped them gain victory in the war, especially during the final stages.



US army cipher device

Interestingly, when former Vice President Aaron Burr and his assistant General James Wilkinson were planning to colonize Spain, they were confused regarding possession of the annexed state. Would it belong to the United States of America or Aaron Burr? Taking advantage of the situation, General Wilkinson who was a Spanish agent changed Burr's coded message, giving a portrayal of Burr's intentions of making Spain his